

Episode 150: Long Ago... 89 1995 Part 9 Meeting the Original Creator in April

Everyone, Happy New Year!

I missed the deadline for last year's final manuscript (ah~uh~) and had to make a slide appearance over the New Year!

Ah, and it was the commemorative 150th episode too...

Such as I am, please treat me favourably this year too.

Like the manuscript, New Year's cards also went over the New Year. These past few years, year-end has been extremely busy, so ultimately writing and sending them on January 2nd or 3rd after the new year begins, like "after-the-fact rock-paper-scissors," has become routine. Ah, I'm sorry. I'm sorry (sweat).

Even so, New Year's cards. The number sent and received decreases yearly. Somehow, cases of greeting by email or sending New Year's card images as email attachments are increasing. And what was quite common this time was not knowing the recipient's address even if I wanted to send one!

Many people know cell phone numbers and email addresses but don't know postal addresses. Certainly nowadays, cell phones and email addresses handle most communication needs. Well, that's our modern lifestyle.

Despite finding New Year's card preparation and sending troublesome, I feel somewhat lonely about New Year's card culture gradually retreating.

Anyway.

April 27th, several days after talking with Seki-san and Umezawa-san, we were in a relatively large meeting room at Shueisha. A very large meeting room divided in half by ceiling-high movable partitions. Truly befitting a major publisher! We were shown to such a meeting room, quietly took our seats, and waited for the teacher's arrival. The so-called "face-to-face meeting" with original creator Yazawa Ai-sensei.

Production staff from Toei Animation included Producer Seki, Series Director Umezawa-san, Series Composition/Script writer Matsui Aya-san, Character Designer Umakoshi Yoshihiko-san, Costume Designer Kawamura Toshie-san, Art Director Yuki Yukie-san, Gyoshin Mitsu-san, Production Manager Kazama-san, and myself. From the TV station, Producer Kotake-san from Osaka Asahi Broadcasting. From main sponsor Bandai Corporation, people from the department making tie-in toys. A representative from advertising agency Asatsu. And the original creator Yazawa Ai-sensei with a representative from "Ribon" editorial department. Such members all gathering face-to-face for a meeting.

Production staff members also properly greeted each other again at this meeting. I often saw Art Directors Yuki-san and Gyo-san at the studio, but this was probably the first opportunity to actually work together. With Character Designer Umakoshi-san, I think this was probably our first meeting. I'd vaguely heard rumours of "a very skilled animator," and maybe we'd passed each other many times before, but this was the first proper introduction. And at this time, we had no idea we'd become a team continuing this Sunday morning broadcast slot for years to come.

And meeting Yazawa Ai-sensei for the first time. I naturally knew she was female, but I thought she'd be older and more veteran-like! But the actual Yazawa-san was a bit younger than us, bright, and in a strange way to put it, seemed like a normal person - that was my first impression. "Ah, this person draws these" - there was fresh emotion!

Oh! Come to think of it, actually meeting a manga artist in person was almost my first time! I'd participated in anime adaptations of manga-based works many times, but with original manga artists, I'd only glimpsed them at wrap parties and such. Even when

creating colours, I'd just work referencing passed-along original colour materials. Meeting and having discussions before a programmes starts like this had never happened before.

Everything made me nervous. My throat kept getting dry and I was drinking tonnes of the provided tea.

Now, the meeting. First, business card exchanges(!) and self-introductions all around. The meeting began with Producer Seki's facilitation.

Seki-san and Kotake-san first explained the programmes overview. About the broadcast slot, roughly the target age demographic and programmes points for appealing to that demographic - explanations following the proposal format. Then Bandai explained how some items appearing in the show would be commercialised as toys for programmes tie-ins. Materials listing several specific commercialisation candidates were distributed.

This was my first experience with such meetings. The very scene of "this is how animation programmess are made!" The realisation that "making programmess is definitely business!" "We create animation footage within such large frameworks." When absorbed in actual work, there's often a self that enjoys it like a hobby despite it being work, but "this is work, part of business." Though I naturally understood this mentally, being in such meetings, such settings, made me feel it keenly for the first time.

Now, Yazawa-sensei's talk. The teacher discussed points she pays attention to when drawing *Neighbourhood Story*, including fashion and animation technique topics. Regarding fashion, we production staff also asked the teacher questions. What should we reference for clothes worn by each character? This was quite an important theme for us. Another concern was digital-ish animation processing. Actually, in *Neighbourhood Story* and previously drawn *Tenshi Nanka ja Nai*, there are pages throughout where images were processed using computers - Macintosh. We asked various questions about that too.

Regarding fashion, Yazawa-sensei would create fashion reference materials by character for us. She'd send them later. About Macintosh: "Ah, I don't really understand that very well (laugh)." Apparently she worked with someone else who handled that part. Then Art Director Yuki-san asked, "Um, there are depictions of manga artists' workplaces..." What kind of atmosphere are manga artists' workplaces? What art supplies are used or placed around? How do they actually draw? These were quite hard to imagine.

"Would you like to come see once?" said Yazawa-sensei. "It would be better for you to actually come see, right?"

That's right. Amazingly, visiting Yazawa-sensei's home for research was suddenly decided!

(11.01.07)